looked possible. In the end, the danger was averted through some timely diplomacy, but seeing how close the two had come to a confrontation despite seven years of border talks, Rajiv Gandhi decided to visit China in 1988 – the first Indian prime minister since 1954 to land in Beijing.

In Beijing, the two sides agreed that, along with normalization, they would continue with border negotiations but now in the form of a dedicated Joint Working Group (JWG). The JWG met fifteen times from 1989 to 2005. The focus of the group was not so much on finding a settlement of the border quarrel; rather, it focused on military stability along the LAC. The results of this more limited aim were the agreements in 1993 and 1996 on confidence building measures and an exchange of maps on the alignment of the LAC in the middle sector. When the two delegations followed up with an exchange of maps on the western sector, their claims were so far apart that they decided to stop the process of further map exchanges so as not to jeopardize the JWG negotiations. This is why China has continued to reject a delineation of the LAC: the delineation efforts made relations more contentious, and it is therefore better to stop trying – reminiscent of Beijing's view in the 1950s and 1960s that it is more fructuous to focus on the strategic 'big picture' in order to find a settlement rather than get immersed in historical and cartographic minutiae. As Huang Xilin, a Chinese official, said to Indian journalists years later in 2015: 'If we find that a clarification of the LAC is a building block, then of course we should go ahead. But if we find that it could become a stumbling block, it could complicate further the situation, then, we have to be careful.'[100]

The third phase of border negotiations and the 2005 agreement

The border negotiations entered a third phase, in 2003, when Delhi and Beijing decided to raise negotiations to the level of Special Representatives who would report directly to the political leaderships. The result of these discussions was an agreement in 2005 titled 'Political Parameters and